

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 2 — “Two Crowns”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.
Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone.
Approx. 20 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — continuing directly from Ch.1)

The two colossal figures step into the pooled light between the gates. They do not so much walk as OVERWRITE the space they occupy. The WHITE POWER: slow, inevitable, like a rising sun. The DARK POWER: jagged, restless, a shadow thrown by fire.
No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, detail — the white power)

Close on the white figure's advancing form — smooth, luminous linework, faint suggestions of cedar branches and clean light dissolving at its edges.
SFX (soft): hummm

Panel 3 (narrow, detail — the dark power)

Close on the dark figure — broken angular hatching, heat-shimmer, the smell of dry earth and old iron implied in the ragged ink.
SFX (low crackle): ksss

PAGE 2

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

The WHITE POWER addresses Egris, its voice lettered clean and crystalline.
WHITE POWER: “You have spilled rivers of blood. You bound a hundred nations under a single law.”
WHITE POWER: “You brought order to the chaos of the steppes.”

Panel 2

Egris, unreadable, listening. The white light washing across his weathered face.
WHITE POWER (off-panel): “For this, there is a place for you. An eternal empire where the sword is finally sheathed.”

Panel 3 (tight)

WHITE POWER (off-panel): “You shall sit at the right hand of the Throne. An architect of a peace that never ends.”

PAGE 3

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top)

The WHITE POWER extends a CROWN of white gold — simple, heavy, unadorned. It does not shine; it glows from within.

WHITE POWER: “Rest, Egris. You have never known a single day of it.”

Panel 2 (large, bottom — Egris’s POV of the crown)

Close on the white crown offered in a luminous hand. Egris’s shadow falls across it.

NARRATION (box): A promise of rest, for a soul that had never rested.

PAGE 4

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

The DARK POWER laughs — a grinding-stone sound — and cuts across the offer.

SFX: GRND-HAHAHA

DARK POWER: “Peace? He did not win his name through peace.”

DARK POWER: “He won it through fire.”

Panel 2

The dark figure leans toward Egris, grin widening, coal-eyes bright.

DARK POWER: “Look at what I offer. A horizon that never ends. Armies of bone and shadow that never tire. Horses that never stumble.”

Panel 3 (tight, intense)

DARK POWER: “Worlds beyond this one that have never heard your name — until you scream it into their skies.”

DARK POWER: “Conquest without limit. Victory without death.”

PAGE 5

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top)

The DARK POWER extends a CROWN of blackened iron — jagged, spiked like frozen lightning, pulsing a dull red heat.

DARK POWER: “For a hand that has always reached for more.”

Panel 2 (large, bottom)

The two crowns now held out from opposite sides of the panel — white-gold left, black-iron right — Egris small and central between them.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6

Panels: 3 (silent reaction page — no spoken dialogue)

Panel 1 (wide)

The kneeling thousands watch, breath held as one collective shiver. The two greatest powers in existence, offering their highest honors to a man in a plain gray robe.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (tight on Egris looking LEFT at the white crown)

Egris studies the white crown. Behind his eyes, a faint vision bleeds into the panel: rows of figures standing perfectly still, heads bowed, none moving unless told. Order as silence. Silence as a cage.

NARRATION (box): A world where no one moved unless commanded. Where every thought was a prayer.

Panel 3 (tight on Egris looking RIGHT at the black crown)

Egris studies the black crown. A second faint vision: endless slaughter with no horizon, a cycle feeding a master who grows fat on the rage of others.

NARRATION (box): A war with no purpose but its own continuation.

PAGE 7**Panels: 4****Panel 1** (tight on Egris's mouth — the first word he has spoken since death)

His voice is raspy, like wind over sand — but it carries to the edges of the plain.

EGRIS: "Order."

Panel 2

The WHITE POWER tilts its head, pleased.

WHITE POWER: "Yes."

Panel 3

EGRIS turns his eyes to the dark figure.

EGRIS: "And war."

Panel 4

The DARK POWER grins.

DARK POWER: "Eternal."

PAGE 8**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top — the beat before)

Egris reaches out with BOTH hands. The powers pause, expecting him to take a crown.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (large, bottom — page-turn setup)

He does NOT take either crown. Instead his weathered hands close around the WRISTS of both figures — gripping the cold white light and the scorching dark at once.

SFX: GRIP

No dialogue.

PAGE 9

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

The air between the gates FRACTURES. Cracks split the empty height. Thunder rolls across the black stone. The gold and red light flicker as if caught in a gale. Both colossal beings are FROZEN — held, for the first time in an eternity, by a mortal's grip. Their shock is enormous and silent. Egris stands at the center, arms outstretched to both, jaw set, utterly unmoved.

SFX (huge, cracking): KRA-KOOM

No dialogue.

PAGE 10

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

Egris speaks, low and hard, his grip tightening on both divine wrists.

EGRIS: "You speak of laws. You speak of spoils."

EGRIS: "You offer me the choice between being a golden slave or a black hound."

Panel 2 (tight two-power reaction — both leaning back from him)

EGRIS (off-panel): "You think because I have died, I have forgotten how to recognize a shackle."

Panel 3 (wide)

He SHOVES both hands away. The two crowns tumble and clatter onto the black stone.

SFX: KLANG-klang

PAGE 11

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS steps OVER the fallen crowns, walking toward the gap between the gates — the narrow path leading straight into the gray, jagged horizon of the Wastes beyond.

EGRIS: "I have conquered living men."

Panel 2 (tight, over his shoulder — he does not look back)

EGRIS: "I will not be conquered by dead gods."

Panel 3 (wide, low)

He walks into the wind, plain gray robe snapping behind him. The two towering powers remain where he left them, crowns abandoned on the stone between them.

SFX (wind returning): hyooooo

PAGE 12

Panels: 1 (near-splash — the closing image)

From behind: Egris, a small solitary figure, walking away down the center path toward the pale, cracked, empty Wastes on the horizon. Behind and above him, for the first time in an eternity, the

TWO ENORMOUS GATES have begun to CLOSE — white and black edges swinging shut on either side, framing his departing back. He does not turn.

SFX (deep, final): ...D000M...

NARRATION (box, lower corner): He chose the road no one had offered him.

— END OF CHAPTER 2 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **Direct continuation of Chapter 1** — the opening panel picks up the exact instant Ch.1 ended (both powers stepping forward). No time gap.
- **The two crowns are the visual thesis** of the chapter. Frame them symmetrically whenever both appear (white-gold on the left, black-iron on the right) so the refusal reads as rejecting BOTH, not choosing between them.
- **Page 6 is the “decision” page** — use the two ghost-visions (order-as-cage / war-without-end) to externalize Egris’s reasoning without an exposition dump. Keep them faint and screentoned, bleeding into the panel rather than boxed off.
- **Page 9 splash (the grip)** is the chapter’s centerpiece page-turn — keep Page 8’s final panel tight and quiet so the fracture lands. This is the first time either power has been physically held; draw their shock as stillness, not flailing.
- **Egris’s first spoken word (“Order,” Page 7)** should be lettered slightly rougher/drier than everyone else — it is the first sound from a man who has been silent since death.
- **The powers’ voices:** white = clean, borderless, weightless lettering; dark = heavy cracked balloons. Keep consistent with Chapter 1.
- **Closing image (Page 12):** the gates CLOSING behind him is the emotional payoff — he is not exiled, he is leaving. The choice is his. Keep his back turned; never show his face on the final page.